

USTC User Research Findings

Flexion UX Research and Design

December 4, 2018

Objective

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The Flexion team needed to gather information from users to help guide the design process for the new case management tool.

Our objective was to gather information on the desired experience for case management within the US Tax Court (USTC) including user preferences, things that work well and ideas that users had for improving systems and processes.

Methodology

Methodology

- Flexion conducted a qualitative study to gather feedback on current system and experience
- Combination of focus groups and 1:1 interviews
- Spoke with 26 USTC users
- Focus group helped us understand the overall system and workflow
- 1:1 gathered detailed insight into their role and processes

Methodology

Flexion conducted the focus group and one-on-one interviews with the following roles:

Assistant Deputy Counsel
Calendar Section Supervisor
Chambers Administrator
Chambers Administrator/Trial Clerk
Clerk of the Court
Court Administrator
Deputy Clerk of the Court
Director of Case Services
Docket Section Supervisor
Docket Section Assistant Supervisor

Docket Clerk
Judge/Chair of IT Committee
Chief Judge
Law Clerk
Legal Assistant to Counsel's Office
Petitions Section Supervisor
Petitions Clerk
Practitioner
Records Section Supervisor
Trial Clerk

Methodology

From those interviews, we learned about:

- Challenges and pain points
- What's working well
- Common tasks for each role
- General user preferences
- Desired features for each role

Methodology

- Analyzed information, identifying positive aspects of the system and current processes
- Uncovered issues that are considered challenging, that could be improved
- Revealed key focus areas from the things we heard the most during the interviews
- Flexion designers discussed and developed recommendations based on findings

Methodology

We've also included a section of ideas or things that were mentioned by a single interviewee that should be noted, but weren't related to any of the challenges or key focus areas.

We're calling these gems "Sprinkles."

Summary of Current Experience

Current Experience – What Works Well

- Current processes are trusted and reliable
- While not the most efficient, the current system does meet the basic needs of the court
- Strong sense of ownership and pride regarding user roles
- Roles and responsibilities are clearly defined

Current Experience – What Works Well

- Many long-term employees have a wealth of knowledge
- General excitement about the idea of building a new, more efficient system
- Interviewees were very receptive to change

Current Experience – Pain Points

- Frequently used, related programs require a separate sign-in
- Many tasks are being completed manually/on paper that could be automated or digitized
- Search and taxonomies are inconsistent and not as efficient as they could be

Current Experience – Pain Points

- Case management notes are recorded inconsistently, and visibility is limited and inconsistent
- Multiple systems, including calendars, provide a disjointed experience
- Document management – creating, editing, scanning, printing – is a cumbersome process

Current Experience – Pain Points

- Payments for petitions and records are manual and managed outside of the current system
- Reporting is manual and data is pulled from many different sources
- Analytics data is not tracked, accessed, or managed
- Inability to view and group cases in context of the user's role

Key Focus Areas and Recommendations

Key Focus Areas

- Technology/Automation
- Case Management
- Integrated Systems
- Reporting and Analytics
- Search
- Calendar Management
- Notifications and Notes

Technology/Automation

Technology/Automation

- Leverage and build upon existing workflows
- Support single-sign on
- Facilitate the docket number “driving the ship”
- Integrate desired features into a single system
- Integrate electronic payments

Case Management

Case Management

- Automated case tracking
 - Status
 - Notifications
- Ability to easily view:
 - Case assignments
 - Case history
 - Case notes
 - Enhanced internal communication regarding a case, e.g., notes and notifications

Case Management - Documents

- Support the ability to attach documents related to a case while another user is working on a case
- Increase maximum file size for internal users to eliminate the need to break apart large documents for upload

Case Management - Documents

- Standardize addresses on petitions
- Provide ability to create, edit, and track versions of documents within the system
- Ability to scan and save exhibit documents individually during a trial session

Case Management - Orders

- Set rules for due dates, e.g., inability to set due dates on holidays or weekends
- Ability for Chambers to communicate with Trial Clerk regarding new documents/exhibits, drafting orders during trial
- Ability for trial clerks to sign orders for judges when in session

Case Management - Orders

- Automatic generation of orders
- Ability to add notes to order in the docket record to provide insight into why the order was generated

Case Management - Opinions

- Automatic, integrated solution for tracking from creation to publishing for easier collaboration
- Automatic generation of opinions within the system
- Ability to manage permissions for viewing and editing opinions

Case Management - Opinions

- Real-time sharing of bench opinions with those in the DC office
- Need reliable and fast way to get exhibit documents back to the DC office for drafting opinions
- Versioning ability for opinions

Case Management - Records

- Automated records forms for requesters with integrated payment
- Facilitate cost calculations and payment for records requests
- Ability to email case documents to requesters upon receipt of payment
- Ability to track physical files and exhibit folders

Integrated Systems

Integrated Systems

- Consolidated experience
 - eTrial
 - eFile
 - Chambers
 - Multiple calendars
- Support payment integration for petitioners
- Facilitate efficient payment tracking for USTC personnel

Reporting and Analytics

Reporting and Analytics

- Enable tracking and reporting
- Provide reporting templates
- Automated scheduled reports
- Ad hoc reporting
- Tracking analytics

Desired Reports

- Case inventory report
- Service report
- Exception reports
 - Cases that shouldn't be set for trial
 - Cases with missing information
- Pending items
- Outstanding due date report
- Closed cases

Desired Reports

- Opinions processed, by judge
- Small tax cases
- Pro se cases
- Attorney-represented cases
- Appellate reports should include open cases
- Track time it takes for a petition to be filed and updated
- Missing case filings report

Desired Reports

- Payment reports
- Statistical reports
 - Number of cases per trial session
 - Jurisdiction retained
 - Due date tracking
 - How many case types per year
 - How many cases were won or lost; how many cases were settled before trial

Search

Search

- Provide the ability to search by docket number
- Provide the ability to keyword search
- Provide the ability to query all data in the system
- Present search results with ability to sort
- Provide filters to narrow search results

Search

Display/filter results by:

- Most relevant
- Most recent
- Date
- Judge
- Year
- Location
- Case type
- Company name
- State
- Area of tax law
- Petitioner name
- Fees paid
- Fees outstanding
- Attorney
- Status

Search

- Ability to search current and historical cases
- Include “fuzzy” search e.g., Green vs Greene
- Ability to search for everything in a single system
- Ability to search within a document

Search

- Need to search by informal keywords e.g., synonyms
- Predictive search
- Research and build a taxonomy to improve findability and enhance search results
 - Tag and categorize data to improve search results
 - Categorize by legal topic, case issues, subject

Calendar Management

Calendar Management

- Fully integrate calendar with case management tool
- Integrate all calendars into a single platform for easy access
- Support the ability to add notes to a calendar
- Ability to apply changes globally to all cases for a trial session
- Enable access to case details from calendar view

Calendar Management

- Ability to view cases by trial session
- Automatic notifications and alerts
- Ability to print calendar with notes
- Ability to view archived information
- Ability to add documents to a scheduled case

Calendar Management

- Ability to easily update calendar when schedule changes are needed e.g., without a Change Notice
- Ability to edit calendar during a trial session
- Ability to view events by:
 - Judge
 - Scheduled date
 - Location

Calendar Management

- Settled cases need to drop from the trial calendar once settled
- List cases per city in a single view, with identifier if information is missing
- Provide an easy way for judges to view available cities and assignments when calendar is complete

Notes, Notifications, and Messaging

Notes

- Case file notes
- Chambers notes
- Calendar notes
 - Before and during trial
 - Add session-level notes to a calendar item
- Unrestricted visibility for notes
- Ability to document details regarding potentially troublesome or bothersome petitioners, as well as protest petitioners

Notifications

- Notify appropriate internal personnel of case activity, e.g., status changes, revisions
- Need a “Hold” notification to prevent a case from being scheduled for trial (99/99/9999)
- Alerts for “no image attached” cases before service is released
- Alerts for "High priority" cases so they can be routed to the general queue to be worked on by the first available clerk

Notifications

- Notifications for file requests and copy requests in the system (currently all in email)
- Notification when case records are eligible for destruction (per record retention policy)
- Notification for items that need action, e.g., a “For action” flag

Messaging

- Send messages to appropriate internal personnel regarding case activity, e.g., status changes, revisions
- Ability to message appropriate internal parties with questions and required action(s)

Recommendations

Tier 1

- Technology/Automation
 - Integrate desired features into a single system
 - Support single-sign on
 - Facilitate the docket number “driving the ship”
- Case management
 - View/access case details and history
 - Case notes
- Case management - Documents
 - Increase maximum document upload file size for internal users
 - Ability to easily scan and save documents individually

Tier 1

- Integrated systems
 - Integrated electronic payments for petitioners
- Reporting
 - Pre-formatted reports
- Search
 - Docket number and petitioner name search
 - Basic filtering of search results
- Calendar management
 - Enable access to case details from calendar view
 - Ability to view events by judge, date, location

Tier 2

- Notes, notifications and messaging
 - Case, calendar, and Chambers notes
 - Ability to message USTC users within the system
- Case management
 - Standardize addresses on petitions
 - Ability to request a file in the system
 - Set rules for due dates
- Case management - Documents
 - Document versioning

Tier 2

- Integrated systems
 - Facilitate efficient payment tracking for USTC personnel for all payment types
- Reporting and analytics
 - Enable ad hoc reports
 - Enable tracking and analytics
- Search
 - Keyword search and advanced filtering
 - Ability to sort search results (relevancy, date, etc)

Tier 2

- Calendar management
 - Support ability to add notes to the calendar
 - Ability to edit calendar during a trial session
 - Ability to add session-level notes to a calendar event
- Notes, notifications, and messaging
 - Case status notifications
 - Calendar notifications
 - Message notifications
 - Records request notifications

Tier 3

- Case management
 - Automatic generation of orders
 - Document templates
 - Create, edit, and track documents within the system
 - Automated records forms for requesters with integrated payment
 - Ability to email case documents to requesters upon receipt of payment
 - Ability to track physical files and exhibit folders in the system
 - Ability for trial clerks to sign orders for judges when in session

Tier 3

- Reporting and analytics
 - Provide reporting templates
 - Automated scheduled reports
- Calendar management
 - Ability to print calendar with notes
 - Ability to add documents to a scheduled case
- Search
 - Ability to query all data in the system
 - Include “fuzzy” search

Tier 3

- Notes, notifications, and messaging
 - Visibility of notes by role
 - Notification when physical case records are eligible for destruction

Tier 4

- Case management
 - Support multi-user access and editing privileges for documents
- Reporting and analytics
 - Statistical reports
- Calendar
 - Settled cases need to automatically drop from the trial calendar (scheduled calendar view) once settled

Dashboard Ideas

Oh, the possibilities!

Dashboard

- Pending items
 - Motions
 - Cases (by judge)
- Case status
 - Scheduled
 - Pending
- Due dates (for responses, filings, etc.)
- Upcoming trials
- Current work queue (due today, etc.)

Dashboard

- Documents waiting for QC and service
- Statistics
 - Amount owed in a case
 - Number of pending cases
 - Case types
 - Upcoming trial sessions

Dashboard - ADC , Deputy Clerk of the Court and Clerk of the Court

- Trial session overview (judges, cities)
- Cases by status for each trial session
- Case assignments
 - Viewing judge's inventory to manage bandwidth
- Pending motions
- Communication/messages from clerks

Dashboard - Chambers Administrator and Trial Clerk

- Direct access to the case file information
- Calendar that automatically updates
- Pending items (motions, cases)
- Due dates (filings, responses due)
- Schedule with location details and reminders for supplies that may be needed when traveling

Dashboard - Court Administrator

- Pending items
- Orders that need review
- Communication/messages that need a response

Dashboard - Docket Clerk and Supervisor

- Case search
- Trial-related tasks for the coming week
- Pre-trial memos

Dashboard - Judge

- Pending deadlines, listed by priority
- Open items, tasks that need attention that day
- Individual tasks
- Tasks assigned to others
- Calendar with all assignments with status indicator, e.g., pending, closed

Dashboard - Law Clerk

- Case status
 - Scheduled
 - Pending
 - Notifications
- A view of all active/current cases
- Quick link to case files
- Ability to filter on status for cases
- Quarterly reports

Dashboard - Legal Assistant to Counsel's Office

- Case status with an alert for a potentially troublesome petitioner or caller
- A view of all active/current tasks
- Due date notifications

Dashboard - Petitions Clerk and Supervisor

- Case search
- Due dates (filings, responses due) with a “Priority” notification for important items
- Any corrections that come back from docket
 - instead of getting it via paper
- Alerts for rule changes that would affect processing of petitions

Dashboard - Practitioner

- Case status
 - Scheduled
 - Pending
- Upcoming deadlines

Dashboard - Records Clerk Supervisor

- Copywork requests
- Filework requests
- Archived file reports for the prior 18 months

Dashboard - Court Administrator

- Communication/messages from clerks

Sprinkles

Facilities Details

“A court specific TripAdvisor.”

- Information about garage parking and access, available from mobile phone
- Distance from airport to courtroom
- Information about preferred and nearby hotels, e.g., is the hotel within walking distance of the court

Enhanced FAQs

“Would be nice if [users] could leave a question on the website so we could answer.”

- Enhanced FAQs could reduce phone calls
- Enhanced FAQs would provide interactive functionality and allow users to ask specific questions that may not be answered in the standard FAQs listings

Conformed Signatures

- When the order is viewed, only a conformed name, not the physical signature should be visible. This would be helpful for validating/confirming the name of the judge on the order to minimize errors.

Private Case Notes for Judges

- Provide the ability for judges to make case notes that are only visible to them

Dashboard Chart and Graphs

- Display charts and graphs for statistical data, such as:
 - Amount owed in a case
 - Number of pending cases
 - Case types
 - Upcoming trial sessions

Mobile

- Access case information and case activity
- Access case files
- View calendar
- Check system messages
- Mobile access for facilities information
- Customized mobile views

Sealed Cases

- Seal cases electronically
- Provide tracking for sealed cases

Questions?

Thank you!